

10.4.2021 Regular School Committee Meeting - NOTES

6:30PM: Roll call: Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: present
Mea Mustone: absent

6:32 Consent agenda; Payroll approved; Minutes are approved from last meeting

6:32: Report of the Superintendent

It is nice for me to be back in the chambers with you tonight. I am happy to share with you that

Some of our Mustang Science teachers took the opportunity to attend training provided by The Life Science Change Agent Teachers Program (LSCAT) – a free, week-long professional development series by AceraEI in partnership with the Medford Public Schools. It included lab activities in gene-editing with CRISPR, microbiomics, and climate change. All three units featured relevant, cutting-edge technology and research aligned to Next Generation Science Standards (NGSS). It is my feeling that this is a great opportunity for teachers to take issues of modern science – like gene editing and climate change – and bring it into the classroom, making a positive impact on what students will be doing in the future. I'm proud that AceraEI is partnering with Medford Public Schools to bring hands-on science education to a new level.

As I stated at our last meeting, Medford is very lucky to have such a supportive business community that assists our district. Last week, Mayor Lungo-Koehn and myself were able to visit Members Plus Credit Union and pick up (100) filled backpacks for those students who might be in need.

Additionally, we would like to thank Target in Everett who donated hand sanitizer for all schools, Goldilox Bagels, for donating their LoX for Love which will benefit each elementary school and 4 Good Vibes Store in South Medford who ran an online Fall Craft Fair which benefited the Medford Public Schools.

Also, I must thank all of the merchants and other organizations who plan to play, donated prizes, and/or sponsored a hole for the Annual Medford Family Network Golf Tournament, hosted by Yoki Restaurant. The tournament, one of the MFN's largest fundraisers, will be held next Monday, October 11th at Sagamore Golf in Lynnfield, so if anyone is interested in playing or donating a prize, please contact the Medford Family Network. They'd love to have you join them! I must say that our Mustang Community is very blessed!

Upcoming Events!

This Wednesday, October 6th is International Walk /Bike to School Day and kicks off Walk/Bike to School Wednesdays this month. These events encourage physical activity as well as promote pedestrian/bicycle safety in both our neighborhoods and our schools.

The Medford Police Department working together with the Shiloh Baptist Church, will be hosting a free family day this Saturday, October 9th outside in the City Hall parking lot, from 10 AM - 2 PM. It will

feature a DJ, food, bike rodeo, car seat checks, and a unity walk. The goal of this event is to bring our community & police together. Our Vocational side of the house assisted the police department by producing flyers and a banner. We were glad to partner with the police on this important youth initiative.

October is Italian American Heritage Month - Over 5.5 million Italians have immigrated to the United States. As you probably know our country, continent as well as our neighboring continent to the south are named after the Italian explorer and geographer Amerigo Vespucci. We celebrate those of Italian heritage who have so richly contributed to America... and the world.

In closing, as the weather is changing and leaves begin to fall, I hope that our Mustang families enjoy making memories apple picking and pumpkin decorating. Take advantage of the outdoor activities while the weather cooperates. Have a good evening!

Public Health Update: Dave Murphy and Avery Hines

Avery Hines: Pooled testing 315 pools: 4 positive pools identified. Nurses found no additional cases from visits to the nurses office. Stay home if sick.

Dave Murphy: Active participation rate: have turned in forms and are showing up for testing.

Participation in testing program:

From the numbers we have received, the school with the lowest number of forms returned has the highest participation rate. About 78% participated.

Paulette Van der Kloot; I see two letters asking specific questions on this.

1. Christina McGorty, North St.: Parent of 2 elementary students: is there any evidence of interschool spread? Any update on buildings testing twice per week? Some first grade students have been unmasking in class during the phonics lesson. Can the district let us know of these situations? Many students are anxious about being unmasked indoors.

Dave Murphy: Last year we had minimal in school transmission. Only one instance of likelihood of inschool transmission. We have had more cases of potential in school transmission at the elementary level. We have more students in the building. More unvaccinated students in closer proximity to one another. Pattern at the Kindergarten level: we heightened protocols with distancing and testing. Not surprising, that we are seeing that with this group. As for testing twice per week, we are stretching our staff and resources considerably when testing. the K students daily. Testing twice per week is not feasible at this time. It is not the case that we are seeing a dramatic increase in positivity or inschool transmission. Looking at the data we are producing, there is not an urgent need to increase the amount of testing district wide. We will follow up regarding the phonics lessons: we are balancing the education risks and the health districts every hour of every day. It is important that we communicate as transparently as possible.

Second letter from Ingrid Moncada: 1. Is there data that switched the testing of Kindergarten students to every day? What is the criteria for quarantining a whole class? 3. What are the guidelines for students staying home? I have heard of students having to pay for PCR tests before sending students back. 4. Has MPS thought about providing free PCR tests to families?

Dave Murphy: 1. Yes. It is difficult to identify who the close contacts are with a group of five year olds who have never been in school before. 2. It has only happened in Kindergarten so far. Not a reflection on staff - just speaks to the age range they are working with. 3. There are times people will draw inferences from incidents that are not happening with regularity.

Avery Hines: if we have students or staff who are symptomatic we like to know about it. Some parents are getting PCR tests on their own but we still want kids symptom free for 24 hours before sending kids back. We would like clearance from health care providers. We have lists of places that give free PCR tests. Please reach out to the nursing office.

Dave Murphy: We would consider providing PCR tests but are pretty stretched with resources right now. We would have to look at how we could execute it. We could maybe offer it once per week but would have to look at the timelines. The timing would not work for all situations for families. We would have to work with the Board of Health on this. I don't want to lose sight of the fact that we are not close to where we were a year ago. We are trending in a positive direction but we need to continue to address the numbers each week.

Kathy Kretz: It is difficult to find the consent form on the website? Can we list it all under one button?

Dave Murphy: We can make it easier to find.

Paul Ruseau: If a student has symptoms but can't be tested, do they get isolated?

Avery Hines: If they do not have a consent form, we try to get verbal consent from the parent. They do get sent home immediately

Paul Ruseau: How are we contact tracing the siblings in other classrooms?

Avery Hines: the close contacts in the sibling classroom undergo the same quarantine protocol as the other siblings close contacts. They would need to quarantine at home as well.

Paul Ruseau: If there is a five year old who is positive, do we immediately test the 7 year old sibling so we can contact trace the classroom?

Avery Hines: We look at each case very closely. We err on the side of caution and test the kids before we even send them out of the building.

Paul Ruseau: Have we considered the travelling nurse programs?

Dave Murphy: The actual participation numbers are a snapshot of three days of testing? In an elementary school, there will be students absent on a day - there can be outliers. If there is only a 25% participation rate in an elementary school, we need to look at it. We will look at it at the end of October to take another snapshot. This is baseline data.

Melanie McLaughlin: Are the protocols on the website?

Dave Murphy: Yes

Melanie McLaughlin: When the students come back, do you require a note from the doctor?

Avery Hines: If there is an alternate diagnosis, yes. They need to show proof that they reached out to the doctor.

Melanie McLaughlin: Have we dug deeper into the participation rate? Why some buildings more than others?

Dave Murphy: We have not yet.

Melanie McLaughlin: It would be good to know. A snapshot over time will certainly help.

Dave Murphy: It is 100% worth asking but each number is just a snapshot. There should not be a discrepancy between consent forms and participation when whole classrooms are walked down together. We have the baseline data now and will take another snapshot at the end of October.

Melanie McLaughlin: For Special Ed students receiving sub separate services getting support at home?

Dave Murphy: It would be the same as if a student were absent in normal circumstances. As far as home tutoring goes, it is the same situation as pre-covid conditions. I would add that our teachers and staff have been very accommodating when we have had to transition a cluster.

Melanie McLaughlin: I am referring to compensatory fees for the speech and ot services they have missed due to quarantine.

Joan Bowen: We will not send staff into homes if students are sick but we will be offering compensatory services. Teachers will reach out to families to see if remote learning can be provided.

Melanie McLaughlin: There is an opportunity for that?

Joan Bowen: That is where compensatory services come into place - when they come back we can offer after school or extended school year.

Jenny Graham: I would like to make sure that the principals are aware they need to get their numbers up. They need to make that happen so we don't see the rates so low. I assume there is additional outreach to

new families and K families. These percentages are not great. I want to make sure that the next time we see this report, the numbers are much better. It is the only way we can rely on the testing program to prevent in-school spread. We need to focus on this as a community. Only way through this that I can see. The vaccination rates need to go up as well.

Dave Murphy: There is an awareness of the priority. It does take time to get the rate higher (it did last year). There is probably a group of people in every community who don't want to adhere to covid protocols. It is a challenge.

Melanie McLaughlin: I am wondering if hard copies can be sent home in back packs.

Dave Murphy: yes they are translated and in backpacks. We will consider pushing it again. They have gone home in backpacks. Many people have communicated back that they will not participate in testing. I know that we will never get to 100 percent. We can target the backpack approach again.

MPS Enrollment report 2021-2022

Noticeable upswing in K numbers: 3 additional K strands

Other fluctuations due to programming decisions (change in EL programming and MEEP numbers)

Joan Bowen: [Out of district report](#) 35 out of district students based on high level of need of specialized programming. MPS continues to be involved in the needs assessment of the students - annual reviews. Numbers fluctuate year to year based on the number of students needing out of district. Students age out at age 22.

Melanie McLaughlin: Is there a cost analysis?

Joan Bowen: 1.2 million dollars for the Out of District placement for the 35 students

Melanie McLaughlin: for the least restrictive environment, each student is assigned to a principal. Who coordinates that placement?

Joan Bowen: Two years ago, the ETLs reached out to the parents to ask if they want the communications: how often. The principals add them to the distribution list so they get information on the clubs, activities at the school. We have families asking for weekly communication so we added them to this list as well.

Melanie McLaughlin: How do we offer them the least restrictive environment so they are not missing out on the community? Have we offered them a survey? A lot of families did not want to leave the district but felt they had to.

Joan Bowen: We have not done a survey but we can work with SEPAC to get this done?

Melanie McLaughlin: That would be great. School events such as curriculum night, are they welcome to attend?

Joan Bowen: Yes, we would love them to attend.

3. Professional Development update: Dr. William Ribas

Peter Cushing: This year in conjunction with our strategic plan, we aimed to provide training for district leaders. I would like to introduce Dr. William Ribas who has provided Professional Development on evaluation and assessment for many years. Experienced teacher, Asst. Principal, Union officer, Asst. Supt., consultant and trainer.

Dr. Bill Ribas: Honor to present to you tonight. We fully integrate the work we are doing with the initiatives already taking place in Medford Public Schools. I am working on performance evaluation and Professional Development. Philosophically, the role of Performance evaluation to develop staff with the intention of leading to higher outcomes. We have worked through the Strategic Plan and the evaluation system which has been approved through DESE and the MTA. A system of performance appraisal needs to be tied into the initiatives in the district.

[Powerpoint Presentation by Bill Ribas](#)

Current Professional Development Programs in the district:

- Social Emotional Learning in the Classroom
- Understanding and Addressing Implicit Bias
- Educator Evaluation: consistent, effective and respectful

Sometimes teachers wait to try out what they learned in a workshop not because they are trying to be difficult but because they have the best of intentions and don't want students to miss out on valuable content as they change their teaching style. If you then evaluate the teachers on the new material being rolled out, then it is more effective.

DESE has provided videos of teaching. We watch the videos together. Admin watch it and evaluate the videos together. Create common expectations across the difference. Need explicit level of criteria for supervisors to look for across the district.

Clearly and respectfully communicate the expectations. Performance rubric in the teachers contract. Important for the teachers to understand what the administrators are looking for and looking at when observing the classroom or student work.

Many teachers don't find the feedback to be useful because the performance mgmt is done separately from the Professional Development. Admin should be looking for the things that were provided during the pd.

When you give the recommendation to improve: what, how and then an offer of support.

Build a partnership to improve teaching, counseling, etc.

Even teachers who don't feel they need the offer of support, they report that it feels good to know that their supervisor is behind them.

In closing: three words that are very important: consistency within schools across schools, higher levels of effectiveness lead to higher performance of teachers and students, lastly doing it respectfully.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Thank you for the presentation. Is there for all K-12 staff?

Bill Ribas: Yes

Paulette Van der Kloot: What is the timeline of this? There is not much time for Professional Development

Bill Ribas: Medford is using the "Train the Trainer" model which is more flexible. There are educators prepared to coach/train on social emotional learning and implicit bias. One principal begins every meeting with one lesson from the SEL session. It is much more cost effective than bringing in trainers every half day.

Paulette Van der Kloot: What is the scope of what you are doing?

Bill Ribas: 20 staff each for Social Emotional Learning and implicit bias.
For evaluation: two full days in the summer along with a three hour training each month with another piece next August with more training next fall. We have structures as to how to sustain and maintain what they have learned.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Social Emotional Learning in the classroom? Can the School Committee take a look at these resources? Core text used with trainers. District office has the text.

Peter Cushing: I have multiple copies you can borrow. Schools have received copies of the books for the libraries.

Bill Ribas: Book is 600 pages long. Would be a very expensive book. We sell the book for \$68 each for MPS. To put it online would cost us thousands of dollars.

Jenny Graham: I would like to understand what measures to make sure the evaluations are done with fidelity after the training is complete?

Bill Ribas: Right now I am the quality control. The administrators have to complete an observation and write the feedback. They need to bring it with the teacher name redacted to the training. They will use it to self assess and then assess one another's. Then they give it to me and I provide the written feedback.

Presentations to the Public: None

Public Comment:

Paul Ruseau: Last week, it became clear that this new format - public comment is not a feature on the agenda but a reminder of what our policy is. Only give public comment to items on the agenda - we did not change that with this new policy. This is not an open mic

Paulette Van der Kloot: The wording is confusing. Can a presentation be a letter?

Paul Ruseau: It can be a power point or people can just come up and speak. Submit the report to the Supt.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Public participation: I receive emails during the meeting. We always have given people the opportunity to make a statement. My fear is that you are cutting out the ability of a person to ask a question. The letter I have here is not meant to start a dialog.

Breanna Lungo-Koehn: My understanding is that a member would bring the item brought up in public comment as an agenda item at a future meeting. Can't be discussed on the floor.

Paulette Van der Kloot: I don't understand if people can't ask a question.

Paul Ruseau: Open Meeting Law dictates that we don't answer questions. All of us fail and violate OML. Send us an email and we will put it on the agenda for a future meeting.

Paulette Van der Kloot: It is my job to read the emails that come to the SC account. It is my job to read these letters. While this policy was intended to correct something

Letter: Parent of Missituk students: I am curious if there will be any dedication or additional signage for the new name?

Paul Ruseau: Point of order. We cannot discuss this.

Melanie McLaughlin: If I understand the process correctly, it will be two weeks before this could go on the agenda.

Jenny Graham: we may want to make a motion to ask the rules committee to create guidance around the SC email account explicitly. We have opened this channel for people to communicate through this email box. There may be more effective ways as to how to handle what comes into that box.

Motion: I would like to make a motion that the School Committee email box be addressed by the rules committee and our public comment policy be revised accordingly.

Roll: 6/0 approved by all. Motion passed to address the School Committee Email Box at the next Rules Subcommittee Meeting.

Sharon Hays: Question about students staying home if symptomatic. If I am understanding you correctly, a parent needs to talk to a pediatrician and the child needs to be symptom free for 24 hours. That will be a lot of disruption for kids. Kids can have a runny nose for days. Maybe it should be discussed more.

Avery Hines: In terms of being symptom free, if they reach out to the provider that they are covid free. We will make it more evident as to what we are looking for. We will increase messaging on that.

New Business:

1. Whereas the McGlynn playground continues to be in substandard conditions; the project for replacement is taking longer than initially anticipated; and the mosquito-borne illness West Nile Virus has been detected in Medford: An update on this project will be provided; and a request will be made by the Mayor to the DPW to clear the standing water at the playground whenever standing water is present to limit the opportunity for mosquito breeding which could threaten our students and staff that use this playground.

- *Offered by Paul Ruseau*

Paul Ruseau: There is another resolution here about this issue. I don't know how to deal with standing water.

Breanna Lungo-Koehn: Yes, please email me or the mayor's email box and I will work to get the DPW there. We have had flooding places we have never had flooding.

Public Comment: Jane Fiorello: I emailed the school committee members with my concerns regarding the McGlynn playground. It is confusing as to who to send issues to. This is an old problem. I noticed over the summer how many holes there are. It is a swamp over there. I went to DPW because I was told there was a line one side is DPW and one side is School Department. I know that there. Not only when it rains. It is like that all the time. I heard from the PTO that this conversation has been going on for a long time. The structures are fine but the holes in the ground are not ok. Please have a civil engineer look at it to see what can be done. Basic safety issues need to be taken care of in the short term.

Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent: Thank you for bringing concerns forward. The next resolution is an attempt to get the ball rolling on fixing the playground.

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: I am going to talk to the city engineer to take a look.

2. Whereas the design study to replace the McGlynn playground was delayed by the COVID-19 pandemic, and whereas unstructured outdoor play promotes the development of important social-emotional skills, be it resolved that the School Committee authorizes up to \$2,000 to conduct a Playground Safety Inspection by a [Certified Playground Safety Inspector](#) at the McGlynn Elementary School playground as quickly as possible. Be it further resolved that the

results of the inspection are presented to the committee so that identified safety concerns can be remediated expeditiously.

- *Offered by Jenny Graham*

The results will be presented to the SC so that issues can be resolved asap. My hope is that we can do the inspection right now so we can remediate it right now while we keep our eye on the RFP.

The safety inspection will help us to do both things at the same time.

Jane Fiorello: I am thinking we need an environmental expert. Appears to be wetlands.

Jenny Graham: The design study will help to look into this - it is on a flood plain.
We want the community to be part of the process.

Motion to approve \$2000 for Inspection of Playground. Approved 6/0.

3. In light of rapidly increasing COVID-19 positive cases in Medford; the low vaccination rate of our eligible students; the nearly 2000 students that are not yet eligible for vaccination; the importance of contact tracing and adherence to protocols designed to limit exposure of our students and staff when positive cases arise: The protocols for contact tracing and communication for close contacts will be presented.

- *Offered by Paul Ruseau*

Paul Ruseau: I would like to know that we have protocols as to what the nurses will follow

Melanie McLaughlin: Pointing to the document from City Hall. This document seems to leave some details out.

Dave Murphy: We can expand on this in the next Public Health report. Nursing Director Avery Hines and her staff follow a strict process as to making contact with the close contacts. We have issues with students come in with symptoms not with close contacts coming in. In large part because of the efforts of the health services staff. If you would like it to be published somewhere, we can do so.

Paul Ruseau; I would be happy to know that it is all on the website.

Dave Murphy: I would be happy to expand the information on the website.

Melanie McLaughlin: I would recommend bullets. Hard to read.

Avery Hines; It was put together with PTOs and the Board of Health.

Melanie McLaughlin: in terms of translation, it would be difficult to make sense of.

Paul Ruseau: This can't be what nurses use. Doesn't account for students who are not testing.

Dave Murphy: I cannot represent that there will never be confusion or questions. There will always be a need for additional information. We are not struggling with these protocols. This year is going well.

Paulette Van der Kloot: I am not clear as to whether a parent needs to give a physical copy of the PCR test

Avery Hines: We are making numerous phone calls with a consistent email. We also attach the DPH (MA) quarantine documentation. We also speak face to face when the parent picks up. I can make the google drive available to all of you.

Paul Ruseau: I would like to say thank you. Our school system does not have systems in place in many areas. This is an area we do have systems in place for this.

Dave Murphy: Ms. Wray and Ms. Hines have certainly developed and executed a tight system with many different layers that keeps kids and teachers safe and in school. We are also working to increase vaccination rates.

Each building is hovering around 90%. No building is below 86.4%. Ms. Hines are still going through one by one to contact those who have not turned in their vax cards. These numbers also include part time hourly workers but it will take more time to get the paperwork in on those people. We will give a report which disaggregates the exemptions that are granted.

Paper passes: 7/0 Information will be presented on the website..

Condolences:

The Medford School Committee expresses its sincere condolences to the family of Leslie George "Bud" Hollenbeck, father of Jan Hollenbeck, our Coordinator of Related Services, Secondary Transition, Section 504 and Assistive Technology.

The Medford School Committee expresses its sincere condolences to the family of Lois Marie (Duffy) Riley, a longtime school crossing guard for the MDC.

The Medford School Committee expresses its sincere condolences to the family of Mary (Kenneally) Mulgrew, sister-in-law of former Medford High School teacher and coach Frank Jewett.

Motion to adjourn: Melanie McLaughlin, seconded by Jenny Graham
6/0 Meeting adjourned at 8:52